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Fighting Google Like They're the British: Evaluating Anticolonial Resistance Methods Against the Digital Platform Metropole

1. Introduction

Colonialism has become a common academic metaphor for describing a wide array of unequal, exploitative relations. Contemporary colonial scholars increasingly argue that colonialism is not defined by the violation of territorial rights, but rather a multitude of social, economic, and political "procedural wrongs," of which none alone can explain its harm.[1] This conceptual pluralism of colonialism has allowed scholars to use it as a historical analogue for a spectrum of modern structures of inequality, from Nkrumah's foundational 1965 "Neocolonialism" to newer fields such as cultural colonialism, academic colonialism, and electronic colonialism. Nick Couldry and Ulises A. Mejias's *data colonialism* and Michael Kwet's *digital colonialism* are two recent attempts to apply the colonial metaphor to the relationship between technology platforms, like Meta, Google, and Amazon, and their users.

At their core, data colonialism and digital colonialism are separate interpretations explaining the shared observation that platforms architect their products in a manner as to extract data from their users in a form that can be appropriated for profit. Both interpretations inherit Andre Gunder Frank's articulation of colonialism as a dichotomy between the wealth-extracting metropoles and the exploited satellites, in which Meta and Google replace England and France as metropoles and their user bases replace colonial territories as satellites.

[1] Lea Ypi, "What's Wrong with Colonialism," *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 41, no. 2 (2013): 160; Laura Valentini, "On the Distinctive Procedural Wrong of Colonialism," *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 43, no. 4 (2015), 313.

However, Couldry and Mejias's data colonialism and Kwet's digital colonialism differ in how they establish the colonial framework of platforms' appropriation of users' data. Couldry and Mejias view historical colonialism as an *analogy* through which modern data appropriation is "best understood," while Kwet views modern data appropriation as a *direct continuation* of historical colonialism.[2]

Several scholars align with Kwet's paradigm of colonial continuation over Couldry and Mejias's framework of colonial analogy. Under this view that data appropriation is a continuation of colonialism and as a result can be resisted as such, these scholars propose the application of 20th century anticolonial methods as possible modes of resistance against 21st century data colonialism.[3] Lilly Irani's Postcolonial Computing and Shakir Mohamed's Decolonial AI are notable examples. However, scholars like Irani and Mohamed primarily justify their proposals epistemologically rather than structurally, leaving the question of whether 20th-century anticolonial resistance methods could practically oppose the material conditions of platforms' data extraction.

I argue that anticolonial resistance methods from the 20th-century decolonization movement fail to generalize to data colonialism specifically because private platforms have replaced nation states as the metropoles of data colonialism. The decolonization movement relied on core motivations of reclaiming territorial sovereignty and fragmenting the metropole's dominion, both of which are ineffective, if not counterproductive, when applied to the platform metropole. In what follows, I first establish the platform as the new colonial metropole, then

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[2] Nick Couldry and Ulises A. Mejias, "Data Colonialism: Rethinking Big Data's Relation to the Contemporary Subject," *Television & New Media* 20, no. 4 (2019), 336.

[3] Unless used to refer to Couldry and Meijas or Kwet's specific interpretation, I will use digital colonialism and data colonialism interchangeably to mean the articulation of platforms' appropriation and accumulation of user data through a colonial framework.

examine two proposed anticolonial resistance methods and the structural reasons each fails, before concluding by orienting towards avenues of resistance beyond the colonial metaphor.

2. Platforms as the new colonial metropole

Historians of colonialism typically use "metropole" to refer to the "country or state" exercising power over foreign peoples and lands, but I argue that what defines the metropole is not its form—whether it be nation-state, head of state, or corporation—but rather its function as the architect and beneficiary of resource extraction across the colonial empire.[4] Andre Gunder Frank defines the metropole relationally, as the economic hub that extracts wealth from a constellation of global, national, and local satellite dependencies.[5] In order to maximize income from its satellites, the metropole has two roles: first, to configure life and labor in its colonies in a way conducive to the maximum efficiency of resource extraction, and second, to leverage the social configuration it created to accumulate the most possible resource wealth.[6] Thus, if we show that these two roles—configuration of life and extraction of wealth—belongs to platforms in the digital realm, it follows that platforms have displaced nation states as the new colonial metropoles of data colonialism.

First, platforms have replaced nation-states as the primary organizer of life and labor. By imposing a new architecture of digital rewards and punishments that displaces the pre-existing legal and economic regulation established by the state. Julie Cohen draws comparison to the colonial fiction of terra nullius to explain this imposition.[7] In 1690, European settlers

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[4] Matthew G. Stanard, *European Overseas Empire,1879-1999: A Short History*, 1st edition, Wiley Short Histories (Wiley Blackwell, 2018), 3.
[5] Andre Gunder Frank, "The Development of Underdevelopment," *Monthly Review* 18, no. 4 (1966), 20.
[6] Couldry and Mejias, "Data Colonialism," 338.
[7] Julie E. Cohen, *Between Truth and Power: The Legal Constructions of Informational Capitalism* (Oxford University Press, 2019), 50.

intentionally framed the New World as a terra nullius, choosing to ignore existing Native American land ownership and governance structures to justify the imposition of European sovereignty and resource exploitation in new colonies. Similarly, Cohen claims that platforms intentionally frame the universe of personal data as a terra nullius, choosing to ignore existing privacy laws and norms to architect and impose of a new social organization that enables the free appropriation of personal data.[8]

Platforms impose two primary architectures upon this terra nullius—one that maximizes opportunity for data production, and one that limits opportunities to act outside of it. On maximizing opportunity for data production, Philip Agre introduces the "capture model" to describe how technology companies restructure human activities in order to capture digital data that can later be exploited for profit.[9] One example is Amazon's restructuring of the ritual of shopping into a digital environment that meticulously captures every customer interaction, creating a continuous behavioral data stream for future exploitation. Similarly, Tiziana Terranova describes how media companies have created a "social factory" of "free labor," where platforms like Instagram constantly employ users to produce labor as a product of unpaid social interactions.[10] Both Agre and Terranova observe how platforms impose architectures that elicit users to produce data everywhere, all the time.

On the other hand, platforms impose architectures that constrain abilities to act outside of them. Lawrence Lessig popularized the notion that "code is law," and that the architectural design choices that platforms code into their software has a regulatory effect that is both similar

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[8] Ibid, 51.
[9] Philip E. Agre, "Surveillance and Capture: Two Models of Privacy," *The Information Society* 10, no. 2 (1994), 111.
[10] Tiziana Terranova, "Free Labor," in *Digital Labor: The Internet as Playground and Factory*, ed. Trebor Scholz (Routledge, 2013), 46.

to and capable of displacing legal regulation.[11] Such regulation by code becomes concerning when the platform's architecture limits a person's ability to form their own moral decisions—Karen Yeung establishes the example of an automatic braking system that prevents a driver from running red-lights, even for justifiable reasons like medical emergency.[12] The inability to act outside of a platform's architectural constraints removes the moral autonomy of the user, limiting their agency to the grammars of action the platform offers, which as discussed before, are optimized for data production.

Next, platforms leverage the production-maximizing and action-constraining architectures described above to accumulate the most possible wealth for themselves. Shoshana Zuboff critiques how Google has created a digital architecture that ubiquitously collects data from across every part users' lives, including email, voice, browsing, search, location, and wearables.[13] Google's ubiquitous capture architecture mines huge amounts of user data which they innocuously term "data exhaust," obscuring the asymmetric relationship of extraction that reduces users to mere sources of raw data for monetization.[14] It is precisely because platforms have restructured life and labor around production that this mass extraction of data is possible.

Combining the observations above, we see that platforms have mastered the skills of configuring labor and extracting wealth from their data subjects, thus fulfilling the two criteria of the colonial metropole. Furthermore, since platforms currently operate on a terra nullius of data regulation, they are able to appropriate resources at a rate comparable to the first-encounter land-grab colonialism of the 1700s, outpacing the grinding, competitive colonialism of the 20th

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[11] Lawrence Lessig, *Code and Other Laws of Cyberspace*, Nachdr. (Basic Books, 2000), 6.
[12] Karen Yeung, "Can We Employ Design-Based Regulation While Avoiding Brave New World ?," *Law, Innovation and Technology* 3, no. 1 (2011), 5.
[13] Shoshana Zuboff, "Big Other: Surveillance Capitalism and the Prospects of an Information Civilization," *Journal of Information Technology* 30, no. 1 (2015), 79.
[14] Ibid.

century. Unlike nation-state metropoles, who are accountable to their citizens, allies, and international organizations, a data platform "exists in the absence of legitimate authority and is largely free from detection or sanction."[15] Thus, platforms do not just replace nation-states as the colonial metropole of data colonialism, but operate more efficiently and free of regulation as well.

3. Applying anticolonial modes of resistance to the data colonial relation

The 20th century decolonization movement developed several new modes of resistance against the colonial national-state metropole, two of which have been proposed as frameworks for resisting data colonialism: the nationalization of natural resources, and the development of decentralized, cooperative systems of production. I argue that both modes fail to cross-apply to the data colonial relation for reasons rooted in the replacement of the nation-state metropole with the platform metropole.

A. Resource nationalization and the vision of national data sovereignty

What if data subjects simply took back ownership of their data?

In 1962, the UN General Assembly unanimously adopted Resolution 1803, provisioning all member states permanent sovereignty over their natural resources.[16] This provision, passed two years after the landmark Resolution 1514 declared colonial rule a violation of human rights, argued that self-ownership over natural resources was a mandatory step for former colonial

[15] Ibid, 83.
[16] United Nations General Assembly, *Permanent Sovereignty over Natural Resources*, A/RES/1803(XVII) (United Nations, 1962).

countries to achieve full sovereignty.[17] Since resource extraction is the foundational principle of colonial rule, Resolution 1803 was the de-facto legal basis that outlawed colonialism.[18]

Resolution 1803 empowered former colonial countries to leverage resource nationalization as a tool for realizing political self-determination.[19] Chilean President Salvador Allende cited the resolution to justify his nationalization of Chile's copper mines as an "exercise of our rights as a sovereign state" against "colonial exploitation."[20] In the fifty years following nationalization, Chile's state-owned copper mines have supplied 10% of global copper, providing the country with a long-term financial surplus.[21] Elsewhere, the Suez Canal has been Egypt's third-largest source of national income since its takeover from France's Suez Canal Company, and the National Iranian Oil company provides 20% of Iran's GDP following its initial nationalization from Britain's Anglo-Iranian Oil Company in 1951 and permanent nationalization in 1979.[22]

Given the historical success of nationalization efforts in resisting colonial resource exploitation, nationalization naturally sounds like a promising method of resisting data appropriation. Throughout the 21st century, dozens of countries and regions, from giants like China and the EU to developing economies like Zimbabwe and Cambodia, have launched

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[17] United Nations General Assembly, *Declaration on the Granting of Independence to Colonial Countries and Peoples*, A/RES/1514(XV) (United Nations, 1960).
[18] Nico Schrijver, *Sovereignty over Natural Resources: Balancing Rights and Duties, Cambridge Studies in International and Comparative Law* 4 (Cambridge University Press, 1997), 372.
[19] Ibid, 4
[20] Salvador Allende, *Enough — No More Dependence!*, UN General Assembly speech (4 Dec 1972) (Progressive International (republication), 2022).
[21] Andrés González et al., "The Nationalization of the Large-Scale Copper Mines in Chile: Successful Investment or Financial Failure?," *Mineral Economics* 37, no. 4 (2024): 787–807.
[22] Ezzat Kenawy, *The Economic Impacts of the New Suez Canal*, Mediterranean Yearbook 2016 (IEMed, 2016); Glenn E. Curtis et al., eds., *Iran: A Country Study*, 5th ed, Area Handbook Series (Federal Research Division, Library of Congress, 2008), 160.

campaigns for data sovereignty—the notion that domestic national control of the servers, networks, and data centers that process, transmit, and store locally-produced data can protect the technological interests of a country from encroachment by foreign bodies.[23] Though motivations for data sovereignty are diverse, former colonial countries, such as Brazil and South Africa, name colonial independence and informational self-determination as motivations to achieve it.[24]

Although a promising and increasingly popular mode of resistance, I argue that digital sovereignty fails to meaningfully disrupt the colonial structure underlying platforms' appropriation of user data.[25] Unlike resource nationalization, which succeeded because colonial countries could seize tangible assets from a physically-present nation-state metropole, digital sovereignty faces a non-territorial platform metropole with intangible resources, ambiguating the appropriate target of seizure. In this section, I will describe how digital sovereignty's definitional and methodological ambiguity enables platforms to hijack and define the term in self-interest, stripping its liberatory potential as a mode of resistance.

First, the term "digital sovereignty" is inherently at tension with itself. In a meta-review of political and legal definitions of sovereignty over the past 400 years, Andrew Woods finds the unanimous elements to be "(1) supreme control; (2) over a territory; (3) independent from other sovereigns."[26] More recent conceptions of sovereignty extend beyond a territorial understanding

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[23] Anupam Chander and Haochen Sun, eds., *Data Sovereignty: From the Digital Silk Road to the Return of the State*, 1st ed. (Oxford University Press New York, 2023), 3; Jonathan A. Obar and Andrew Clement, "Internet Surveillance and Boomerang Routing: A Call for Canadian Network Sovereignty," *TEM 2013: Proceedings of the Technology & Emerging Media Track*, 2013, 2.

[24] Government of South Africa, "Draft National Policy on Data and Cloud," Republic of South Africa, April 1, 2021; Min Jiang and Luca Belli, "Introduction: Contesting Digital Sovereignty: Untangling a Complex and Multifaceted Concept," in *Digital Sovereignty in the BRICS Countries: How the Global South and Emerging Power Alliances Are Reshaping Digital Governance*, Communication, Society and Politics (Cambridge University Press, 2025).

[25] Owing to the definitional ambiguity explained in the next few paragraphs, I use "digital sovereignty" as a superset of "data sovereignty"; otherwise, they are interchangeable with one another.

[26] Andrew Keane Woods, "Litigating Data Sovereignty," *The Yale Law Journal*, 2018, 360.

to also include the man-made infrastructure and natural resources bounded within the territory—however, the requirement of supreme authority over these resources remains constant.[27] This absolutist perspective creates an issue in the 21st century—as private platforms usurp the regulatory and market authority of nation states, the ability for any government to hold supreme sovereignty over their resources and territory becomes increasingly untenable. Global interdependence from trade, treaties, and telecommunication networks creates overlapping jurisdictions of authority that makes the language of sovereignty inadequate to the contemporary era.[28] Arjun Appadurai characterizes this increasingly fragmented distribution of authority as "many small nations 'without states' claiming partial forms of sovereignty," in which non-state "nations" like multinational corporations, indigenous coalitions, and independent regulators claim nationhood and project microclaims of sovereignty over infrastructure and resources.[29] Thus, the digital domain of data colonialism fundamentally challenges efforts of nationalization and sovereignty because a) supreme authority cannot be reclaimed over non-rivalrous resources like data, and b) non-state nations like digital platforms transcend territorial boundaries, blurring what it means to re-take a resource back within one's borders.

Despite the unstable conceptual foundation of digital sovereignty, it is still helpful to explore its anticolonial potential given the large amount of postcolonial countries seeking to achieve it. Although a Westphalian conception of absolute sovereignty is untenable over digital technology (bar extreme examples like North Korea), scholars of cyberspace have worked

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[27] Stephane Couture and Sophie Toupin, "What Does the Notion of 'Sovereignty' Mean When Referring to the Digital?," *New Media & Society* 21, no. 10 (2019), 2308; Daniel Philpott, "Sovereignty," *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2020.
[28] Couture and Toupin, "Digital Sovereignty," 2308; Brenna Bhandar, "The Conceit of Sovereignty: Toward Post-Colonial Technique," in *Storied Communities*, ed. Hester Lessard et al. (University of British Columbia Press, 2011), 71.
[29] Appadurai, "Disjuncture and Difference in the Global Cultural Economy," 304, quoted in Couture and Toupin, 2308.

towards formulating new theories of exercising sovereignty in the digital domain.[30] Luciano Floridi defines digital sovereignty as government "control of data, software (e.g., AI), standards and protocols (e.g., 5G, domain names), processes (e.g., cloud computing), hardware (e.g., mobile phones), services (e.g., social media, e-commerce), and infrastructures (e.g., cables, satellites, smart cities)."[31] Ke Xu buckets these domains into a physical layer (physical infrastructure), code layer (regulations, standards, and domains), and data layer.[32] The achievement of sovereignty, as an absolute authority, therefore requires a country to control all three layers.

Nationalization of just a subset of these layers, although easier, ultimately causes adverse effects. First, the sole nationalization of the physical layer is conducive to authoritarian governments using sovereignty as a cover for population monitoring—for instance, Cambodia's proposed "National Internet Gateway" would route all internet traffic through government networks, while continuing to permit platforms like Meta to collect and process Cambodian user data.[33] Second, the sole nationalization of the code layer typically consists of laws inspired by the EU's GDPR, including Nigeria's NDPR and Kenya's Data Protection Act. Without control over physical or data layers, GDPR-modeled frameworks leave platforms able to exploit loopholes and noncompliance. Third, the sole nationalization of the data layer fails because without control over the physical and code layers, there is no mechanism to enforce it. South Korea requires that mapping data be stored in the country; as a result, local companies and

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[30] John Perry Barlow, "A Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace," Electronic Frontier Foundation, February 8, 1996; Milton Mueller, *Will the Internet Fragment? Sovereignty, Globalization, and Cyberspace*, Digital Futures (Polity Press, 2017).
[31] Luciano Floridi, "The Fight for Digital Sovereignty: What It Is, and Why It Matters, Especially for the EU," *Philosophy & Technology* 33, no. 3 (2020), 370.
[32] Ke Xu, Data Security Law: Location, Position and Institution Construction, 3 Bus. & Econ. L. Rev. 52, 57 (2019).
[33] Chander and Sun, Data Sovereignty, 7.; Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, "Cambodia: Data Surveillance Legislation Is Repressive, Must Not Be Implemented – UN Experts," United Nations Human Rights Office of the High Commissioner, February 2022.

individuals are constrained to inferior domestic mapping apps, while foreign platforms can freely access South Korean maps from abroad. In all three of these cases, the extractive relation between private platforms and data subjects persists through the intervention.

These three modes of failure carry that meaningful, enforceable digital sovereignty requires a government to simultaneously control all three layers, requiring a technological, financial, and legislative power that is often out of reach for former colonial countries. In the wake of Edward Snowden's leaking of the NSA's global digital surveillance programs, Brazilian president Dilma Rousseff began a campaign to assert digital sovereignty by separating Brazil's internet from the influence of the U.S. government and Big Tech companies.[34] Despite Rousseff's vision of technological independence and Brazilian data sovereignty, the majority of Brazilian data continues to be processed in foreign data centers.[35] In 2025, Brazil's finance minister reasserted that local data sovereignty is necessary to protect citizens' information, but admitted that economic and regulatory barriers prevent the country from meeting its internal data processing needs.[36] This gap between the political intent to nationalize data and technological ability to do so has controversially led former colonial countries like Brazil and South Africa to contract American hyperscalers like AWS, Microsoft Azure, and Google Cloud to establish domestic sovereign clouds.[37]

The immediate paradox with Brazil and South Africa hiring foreign hyperscalers to build out digital sovereignty infrastructure is that the companies contracted to implement these

[34] Sybil D. Rhodes and Leslie Elliott Armijo, "Brazilian Leadership and the Global Internet," AULA Blog, April 28, 2014.
[35] ARTICLE 19, "Brazil: Data Centres and the Tales of 'Digital Sovereignty,'" ARTICLE 19, January 27, 2026.
[36] Simone Kafruni, "Haddad Diz Que 60% Dos Dados Do País São Processados No Exterior," Poder360, August 23, 2025.
[37] Tatiana Dias, "As Big Techs Transformaram Soberania Em Produto – e o Brasil Comprou," The Intercept Brasil, October 20, 2025.

countries' sovereign clouds—namely Amazon and Google—are the same companies that operate the extractive platforms that constitute the data-colonial metropoles. As such, AWS and Google Cloud have minimal incentive to build systems that actually fortress a country's data, creating a performative digital sovereignty that Grohmann and Barbosa coin as "sovereignty-as-a-service."[38] This performativity becomes especially apparent when reviewing the fine-print of hyperscalers' cloud sovereignty services. AWS advertises its Sovereign Cloud offering as an innovative and disruptive enclave of its public cloud that is "sovereign-by-design," but fails to elaborate further.[39] In reality, AWS Sovereign Cloud's features largely exist within status-quo legal frameworks of international data sharing, albeit with enhanced infrastructural control and data encryption.[40] Similarly, Google's "Sovereign Cloud from Google" is not a unique technical offering, but rather an online tool that asks customers multiple-choice questions about their data governance, operational, and technical needs before recommending appropriate off-the-shelf Google products.[41] Google reframes data sovereignty from a liberatory technopolitical goal to an engineering paradigm to be achieved through its ecosystem of Google Cloud and Google Workspace tools.[42] Amazon and Google's digital sovereignty programs redefine digital sovereignty as a branded commercial product rather than a political project of national reclamation. Amazon and Google's vested interest as data platforms provides incentive for their sovereignty programs to remain inert, protecting the global flow of national data that protects their positions as data-colonial metropoles.

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[38] Rafael Grohmann and Alexandre Costa Barbosa, "Sovereignty-as-a-Service: How Big Tech Companies Co-Opt and Redefine Digital Sovereignty," *Media, Culture & Society* 48, no. 2 (2026), 17.
[39] Amazon Web Services, "Digital Sovereignty at AWS," Amazon Web Services, 2026.
[40] Grohmann and Barbosa, Sovereignty-as-a-Service, 420.
[41] Google Cloud, "Sovereign Cloud from Google," Google Cloud, 2026.
[42] Grohmann and Barbosa, Sovereignty-as-a-Service, 420.

Amazon and Google are able to advertise hollow Sovereign Cloud products to governments precisely because digital sovereignty was always a conceptually unstable term. As discussed earlier, the Westphalian, Hobbesian notion of territorial sovereignty, guaranteed by UN Resolution 1803 and exercised by Allende in Chile's copper nationalization, is fundamentally untenable when applied to digital resources appropriated by corporate platforms that operate both across and above national jurisdictional boundaries. Werner and de Wilde observe this "descriptive fallacy" of sovereignty applied to the globalized digital contemporary, and propose that the term is undergoing a "linguistic turn" away from a descriptor of absolute sovereignty towards an activist "speech act to (re-)establish the claimant's position as absolute authority" over some domain.[43] Body sovereignty, food sovereignty, and now digital sovereignty are all speech acts leveraged by indigenous scholars, grassroots movements, and nation-states alike to use sovereignty as a metaphor for reclaiming agency.[44] Krippendorff's constructivist account of metaphors warns that any term employed by social actors to describe a perceived reality can be controlled by the actor with the most power. Having the greatest financial depth and infrastructural reach, Amazon and Google are positioned to win the contest to define digital sovereignty on their own terms.

In this section, we see that the platform metropole has subverted technological nationalization as a means of anticolonial resistance. Former colonial countries that attempt partial data sovereignty find that the extractive data relation persists through the gaps, while those that attempt full-stack sovereignty must contract the same platforms they seek independence from.

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[43] Wouter G. Werner and Jaap H. De Wilde, "The Endurance of Sovereignty," *European Journal of International Relations* 7, no. 3 (2001), 287.

[44] Couture and Toupin, "Digital Sovereignty," 2306.

One caveat to this argument is that it assumes the role of data nationalization and establishing digital sovereignty is that of the postcolonial nation state, which relies on a Westphalian assumption that only nation states can be sovereigns. However, there is a growing scholarship exploring the possibilities of non-state data micro-sovereigns. Milton Mueller's "Popular Sovereignty in Cyberspace" proposes a vision in which individual subjects reclaim personal sovereignty over their data, and Kukutai and Taylor extends scholarship on indigenous sovereignty to show how non-state communities can assert data sovereignty against corporate platforms.[45] Both of these theories embrace a model of a "nation outside a state," that allows for smaller reclamations of authority without necessity for national investments in infrastructure and absolute territorial control over data. We explore these grassroots, commons-based methods of resistance in the next subsection.

B. Decentralized alternatives the vision of a cooperative digital commons

Indigenous data sovereignty, as introduced by Kukutai and Taylor, is distinct from the prior subsection's discourse of data sovereignty regarding state governments focused on issues of legal jurisdiction. Rather, it is a communal movement, striving towards self-determination through grassroots organization outside the authority of nation states and corporations.[46] Indigenous scholars note that native peoples have always collected data in pursuit of their own goals, with examples of Plains Indians enumerating wild game during winter hunts and nations in the Pacific Northwest carving civic records on totem poles.[47] While these forms of internal data collection were self-motivated, interactions with nation-state data collection have

[45] Mueller, Will the Internet Fragment?, 2017; Tahu Kukutai and John Taylor, eds., *Indigenous Data Sovereignty: Toward an Agenda*, Centre for Aboriginal Economic Policy Research (CAEPR) (ANU Press, 2016).
[46] Kukutai and Taylor, eds., Indigenous Data Sovereignty, 1.
[47] Ibid, 254.

historically been appropriative and extractive. One notorious example is blood quantums in the U.S., in which the Bureau of Indian affairs collected blood samples from natives to quantify if they had enough "indian blood" to be eligible for payouts from land cession treaties. Often, these tests intentionally collected and processed data in a manner that disqualified most Native Americans from receiving compensation.[48] The detachment of Indigenous data systems from that of the colonial government therefore provides communal self-determination, fostering an ability to collect and process data according to self interest. Since 2010, Indigenous nations around the world have developed self-owned demographic datasets, culturally-aligned wellbeing surveys, and localized statistical frameworks as community projects that resist both settler colonialism from the nation state and data colonialism from platform metropoles.[49]

The idea of resisting data appropriation by creating communal, cooperative, and self-dependent data ecosystems is gaining global traction beyond Indigenous communities. Michael Kwet characterizes this movement as a "digital commons solution, rooted in libertarian socialist principles of self-governance, decentralization, and federation."[50] He provides the example of the social media network Mastodon, an alternative to Twitter/X which operates as a federation of smaller independently-operated social media "instances." Each instance is hosted on its own data server, and publishes its data privacy rules to provide users an informed choice of which instances to join.[51] This combination of self-ownership, transparency, and user agency creates a democratic digital commons that resists the opaque, extractionary architecture of social media platforms like X or Meta. Beyond social media, bootstrapped public datasets, open-weight

[48] Ibid, 260.
[49] Ibid, 276.
[50] Michael Kwet, "Fixing Social Media: Toward a Democratic Digital Commons," *Markets, Globalization & Development Review* 5, no. 1 (2020), 1.
[51] Ibid, 5.

LLMs, and the Free Software movement are examples of digital commons solutions built to provide an alternative to dependency on data platforms.

Self-governed, decentralized, and cooperative movements have historically proven successful at resisting colonial exploitation by an occupying nation-state. In *The Tunnels of Cu Chi*, Tom Mangold describes the elaborate underground supply chains the Viet Cong established for producing and distributing resources across its vast federated network of fighting cells. While the U.S. metropole would leverage its colonial resources to ship food and weapons en masse from the American mainland, the Viet Cong's "underground metropolis" of tunnels housed kitchens, weapon workshops, livestock pens, hospitals, and store rooms capable of producing food and fighting equipment from nearly anywhere across its vast federated network.[52] The underground and decentralized nature of the Viet Cong's tunnels provided safety against U.S. attacks, and when taken as a whole, the distributed network of food and weapons production matched up to the resource production of the United States. Eventually, the Viet Cong's distributed resource commons persevered over the U.S. Army's concentrated supply chain.

When applied to data colonialism, however, I argue that the liberatory potential of digital commons solutions is fundamentally trapped by the platform metropole. Unlike the food and weapons produced in localized small batches by the Viet Cong, data necessarily requires concentrated scale to be productive for use cases like retrieval, inference, and classification. Since platform metropoles already monopolized the preconditions of scale—financial resources, technical infrastructure, and network effects—digital commons movements are forced to either scale by adopting extractive methods of accumulation, or remain small, fragmented, and ineffective.

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[52] Tom Mangold, *The Tunnels of Cu Chi: A Harrowing Account of America's Tunnel Rats in the Underground Battlefields of Vietnam*, 1st ed (Random House Publishing Group, 2013), 71.

The inability to collect data at scale commonly limits the efficacy of grassroots digital commons projects. For example, because Meta and Google's proprietary multilingual content moderation models systematically disadvantage low-resource language speakers, there is a popular movement among AI fairness researchers to bootstrap community-built, language-native alternatives. Farhana Shahid surveyed 22 AI researchers working on low-resource language content moderation pipelines, and found nearly all faced the common problem of data scarcity. Researchers complained Big Tech social media platforms owned the largest text corpuses of low-resource languages, but monopolized this data to train their own proprietary large language models, or in the case of Reddit, to sell to foundation AI providers like OpenAI.[53] Instead, researchers had to rely on low-quality datasets like conquistador-era bible translations and volunteer annotations to compile even a meager amount of training data.[54] For languages that do happen to have large datasets, like Swahili, researchers still struggled to train models due to a lack of funding, computational power, and appropriate hardware.[55] The underlying issue across researchers' complaints is that bootstrapping digital commons projects like content moderation pipelines requires large-scale data, infrastructure, and financial resources that platforms hoard in their walled gardens. Without scale, communal projects fail to compete with the product quality of platforms, reinforcing community dependence on the platform metropole.

Digital commons projects can never achieve the scale of data possessed by platforms, since platforms accumulate their data through modes of dispossession that violate the fundamental socialist principles of the digital commons. We can view the initial growth of data

[53] Farhana Shahid et al., "Think Outside the Data: Colonial Biases and Systemic Issues in Automated Moderation Pipelines for Low-Resource Languages," 2025, 8.
[54] Ibid, 10.
[55] Ibid, 7.

platforms through Marx's lens of primitive accumulation.[56] At their conceptions, platforms like Facebook and Google scaled their initial repository of data through logging user interactions from core products like the Facebook timeline and Google search. As these platforms scaled and became more profitable, they accumulated what David Harvey calls "overaccumulated capital"––surplus wealth that exceeds a company's existing opportunities for profitable investment.[57] To capture investment returns on overaccumulated capital, Harvey argues companies must seize exploitable assets in the public domain from which the overaccumulated capital can generate returns. For Facebook and Google, this meant expanding the realm of capturable data that could be appropriated for profit. Meta's purchase of WhatsApp, Instagram, and Oculus appropriated data from user conversations, photos, and movement. Google's Maps, Home, and Fitbit appropriated data from user locations, questions, and health. This phenomenon of increasingly intimate data appropriation can be characterized by Harvey's theory of "Accumulation by Dispossession," where companies accumulate increasing amounts of wealth from dispossessing, privatizing, and appropriating assets previously belonging to the personal or public domain.[58] The final result of this compounding accumulation is a self-perpetuating cycle—platform metropoles hold immense amounts of information from any aspect of a user that could be captured as data, which in turn generates more overaccumulated capital that drives further dispossession. Decentralized, grassroots, digital commons projects can therefore never compete with the data scale of platforms. Accumulation by dispossession violates fundamental principles of the digital commons movement, such as growth without user exploitation and generation of inequality. Beyond the violation of principles, digital commons projects cannot practically

[56] Karl Marx, "Capital, Volume I, Chapter 26: The Secret of Primitive Accumulation," 1867.
[57] David Harvey, "Accumulation by Disposession," in *The New Imperialism*, by David Harvey (Oxford University Press, 2003), 149.
[58] Ibid.

collect through communal bootstrapping the scale of data that platforms appropriated through primitive accumulation. Thus, digital commons projects will be forever cursed with a problem of data scarcity.

The pragmatic constraints of cooperative projects—including data scarcity, funding, trust, and adoption—coerce projects to sustain themselves through an adoption of the appropriative measures of the platform metropole. Vili Lehdonvirta chronicles the evolution of oDesk (now Upwork) from a startup intended to enable trusted collaboration between remote software engineers into one of the world's largest gig labor platforms.[59] For each barrier oDesk faced in development, it created a solution that appropriated slightly more data from its users. To ensure trust between remote collaborators, oDesk introduced screen monitoring and time tracking. To boost adoption, oDesk allowed users to advertise themselves to potential collaborators through profiles, which gradually required increasingly detailed personal information. Like the metaphor of the camel's nose, in which permitting a camel to warm its nose under the tent eventually results in the camel inside and the owner outside, these incremental, benign responses to pragmatic issues collectively transformed oDesk from a good-faith cooperative project into one of the predominant platform metropoles that organizes modern labor.

We conclude that digital commons projects—federated, community-based alternatives to platform metropoles, are inherently incompatible with the accumulatory and extractive logic needed to create data systems capable of useful recall, inference and classification. Terranova argues that this necessary dependency on accumulation and extraction is *itself* part of the larger mechanism of late capitalism, since the dependency creates the self-reproducing demand for

[59] Vili Lehdonvirta, *Cloud Empires: How Digital Platforms Are Overtaking the State and How We Can Regain Control* (The MIT Press, 2022), 74.

labor that sustains late capitalism.[60] As such, grassroots alternatives to platforms experience a double bind in the face of data scarcity—either remain committed to its libertarian socialist principles and die out, or adopt the accumulation-by-dispossession logic of the platform metropole and lose its liberatory potential. Unlike the nation-state metropole, whose extractive infrastructure could be physically countered through decentralized community resistance, the platform metropole's extractive accumulatory logic is underwritten by capitalism and cannot be seized, only replicated. Trebor Scholz cynically notes that with a few exceptions like Wikipedia and Craigslist, "the Internet is so intensely subjugated to corporate interests that even if you jump ship, if you abandon the Facebook Titanic today, chances are that you are jumping on to the next life raft that is likely just as profit oriented."[61] Even projects like Wikipedia and Linux— hailed as examples of decentralized peer production by scholars like Yochai Benkler—are now exploited by Big Tech companies as pools of free data and software, thus being reduced to arms of Terranova's social factory.[62] Thus, data colonialism, as a product of the platform metropole's foundation in capitalist accumulation, inherently neutralizes federated community-driven attempts at resistance.

4. Anticolonial resistance is structurally incompatible with the platform metropole

In the last section, we diagnosed the points of failure for two anticolonial modes of resistance—resource nationalization and grassroots organizing—when cross-applied to data colonialism's platform metropoles. Resource nationalization gets disrupted because the notion of sovereignty it requires cannot be cleanly transferred to digital space. Even if digital sovereignty

[60] Terranova, "Free Labor," 51.
[61] Trebor Scholz, ed., *Digital Labor: The Internet as Playground and Factory* (Routledge, 2013), 15.
[62] Yochai Benkler, *The Wealth of Networks: How Social Production Transforms Markets and Freedom* (Yale University Press, 2008), 17.

was cleanly defined, postcolonial nations do not have the resources to achieve it without, ironically, contracting platforms themselves for assistance. On the other hand, grassroots organizing fails because the socialist libertarian principles of the "digital commons" are incompatible with accumulating the required magnitude of data necessary to compete with platforms. Without data at scale, projects must choose to either die out or give up their community-driven principles.

The common fundamental failure that these two techniques demonstrate is that the fragmenting impulse of the anticolonial movement is at direct opposition to the centralized scale necessary for building modern technology. Data-centric innovations of the past decade not just thrive on, but require, scale—social media's dependence on network effects, AI's dependence on big-data inference, and cloud computing's dependence on stadium-sized server farms provide notable examples. Thus, the fragmenting goal of anticolonialism is at fundamental odds with the inherent accumulating nature of emerging technology like LLMs.

A driving goal of 20th century anticolonialism was to break apart the colonial empires governed by nation-state metropoles[63]. This goal was feasible because the survival of the international order does not benefit from the existence of large states; if anything, large hegemonic superpowers are producers of international political instability. Even after the decolonial fragmentation of the British Empire, for example, the resulting collection of smaller born nation states—the Commonwealth—are functional members of a healthy United Nations. The core logic of international relations is transformed, but not challenged, by anticolonialism. Unlike the international order, however, we have established how contemporary digital technology *is* dependent on scale. Thus, the existence of large platforms is necessary to

[63] Martin Thomas, *The End of Empires and a World Remade: A Global History of Decolonization* (Princeton University Press, 2024), 2.

accumulate and provide the data, capital, and infrastructure needed to feed this demand for scale. A small platform cannot optimally perform inference, sustain network effects, or maintain always-available infrastructure. The survival of contemporary AI, social media, and other technologies are therefore directly challenged by the anticolonial logic of fragmentation. Anticolonial modes of resistance, like data sovereignty and digital commons, not only threaten the platform metropole, but the technological innovations that the platform makes possible. The platform metropole is therefore distinct from the nation-state metropole in an important way—the platform metropole upholds the digital context in which it exists, while the nation-state metropole simply sits atop its geopolitical context. Google, Meta, Amazon, and their research labs, however dispossessive and exploitative, provide the infrastructure, data, and code that defines technological progress. Anticolonial resistance that liberates the international order instead sabotages the digital domain, and is therefore inappropriate when cross-applied as a resistance method against platforms' exploitative data practices.

Given these different affective purposes of the nation-state metropole and platform metropole, it follows that modern-age data colonialism is fundamentally different from 20th-century administrative colonialism. Kwet's characterization of digital colonialism as a chronological continuation of the historical colonial exploitation of the Global South frames resistance through the same goal of breaking apart the metropole. Namely, the three solutions Kwet proposes in his foundational paper of digital colonialism—community-based technology, internet decentralization, and ideological pluralism—are all founded on the principle of fragmentation that we problematize in the previous paragraph. By framing data colonialism as a parallel to, rather than continuation of, administrative colonialism, Couldry and Mejias avoid the trap of territorializing data colonialism and its resistance methods. Couldry and Mejias

underscore the fact that data colonialism operates beyond territoriality, operating on foreign and domestic populations alike across Global North-South, East-West divisions.[64] Without territory to break apart, fragmentary modes of resistance become inadequate. Instead, Couldry and Mejias look towards solutions that don't seek to fragment the platform metropole, but rather challenge its fundamental legitimacy by attacking "the underlying rationality that enables continuous appropriation to seem natural, necessary, and somehow an enhancement of, not a violence to, human development."[65] To Couldry and Mejias, the problematic aspect of data colonialism is not inherently platforms' vast wealth, but instead the extractive, degrading, yet legitimized ways that they accumulate it. Thus, concentrating resistance on preventing the extractive techniques employed by platforms, instead of fragmenting their territorial monopolies, can still provide justice to data subjects without undermining the role of platforms as the providers of scale that enable contemporary technological development.

Administrative colonialism between a nation-state metropole and its peripheral colonies is an inherently territorial relation. If we, as Couldry and Mejias suggest, resist data colonialism not by fragmenting its territorial accumulation but rather by challenging its extractive and appropriating rationality, we may be able to look beyond the colonial analogy altogether. Drawing on Harvey's theory of accumulation-by-dispossession and Terranova's theory of the social factory, we see that at its core, data colonialism's appropriating rationality is built on a foundation of capitalism. So what insights can broader theoretical fields, such as informational capitalism, tell us about how to resist the "rationality of continuous accumulation" that Couldry and Mejias describe? Julie Cohen argues that the legitimacy of information capitalists' extraction and appropriation is not an a priori truth, but rather a product of existing legal frameworks.

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[64] Couldry and Mejias, "Data Colonialism," 337.
[65] Ibid, 345.

Cohen provides the example of immaterial property rights like copyright being constructed in ways that protect platforms' proprietary algorithms while leaving the user data these algorithms ingest unprotected.[66] Since governments constructed the legal foundation that enable platforms to appropriate data, Cohen argues the solution to stop data appropriation is for governments to re-evaluate this legal foundation.

Frameworks like Cohen's that foreground platforms' foundational logic of capitalist accumulation can provide tighter, more applicable methods of resistance than frameworks dominated by the colonial metaphor. Kwet's theory of digital colonialism remains tethered to the territorial logic of administrative colonialism, thereby limiting its liberatory potential. Couldry and Mejias's theory of data colonialism makes targeted concessions, allowing it to provide more reasonable modes of resistance. The substitution of the nation-state metropole with the platform metropole is one of many differences that sets contemporary data appropriation apart from administrative colonialism, and as such, strategies for combatting this contemporary issue cannot remain nostalgically attached to the past. Rhetoric like "radical imagination" and "taking a leap of faith against the oppressor"—the ultimate forms of anticolonial resistance employed by the FLN and Viet Cong—can only guide our action against Google, Amazon, and Meta so much, after all.

5. Conclusion

In closing, I think it is worthwhile to reflect on what the intended purpose of tech-colonial frameworks are in the first place. Both Couldry and Mejias and Kwet describe their frameworks as tools of *understanding*. Specifically, viewing Big Tech platforms' appropriation

[66] Cohen, Between Truth and Power, 16.

of their users' data through the structure of colonialism clarifies the extractive economic and social mechanisms through which platforms accumulate their wealth. The usage of colonial studies as a framework allows us to leverage decades of domain knowledge against the relatively new issues that big data poses.

Despite the value of colonial frameworks for understanding platforms' digital extraction, I show the dangers of extending them further as frameworks for resistance. In this paper, I articulate a distinction between data colonialism's platform metropole and administrative colonialism's nation-state metropole in order to show that although both serve a similar structural purpose, they operate in different ways that necessitate distinct modes of resistance. While reclaiming territorial sovereignty and fragmenting the metropole's imperial dominion were effective against the nation-state metropole, the platform metropole's non-territoriality and accumulation logic make both impulses ineffective, if not counterproductive.

Instead, resisting data colonialism—and the underlying logic of capitalist accumulation that it represents—requires a tailored theory of power that adapts to the specific mechanisms of the platform metropole. I have established several unique tenets of platform metropoles, including non-territoriality, resistance to decentralized replacement, and being a necessary social provider of technological scale. Thus, a promising theory of resistance needs not to aim for platforms' territorial fragmentation, but rather specifically address the frameworks that legitimize unjust extraction and appropriation—this is the orientation that theories like Cohen's informational capitalism gestures toward. While the colonial metaphor provides a useful framework for understanding platforms' extractive logic, resisting it requires abandoning the metaphor in favor of a theory of liberation purpose-built for the modern metropole.

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